

Teaching Statement

For me, teaching finance is not simply about explaining formulas or models; it is about helping students understand why those tools matter and giving them the confidence to use them. One of the most rewarding moments in teaching is seeing a concept that initially seemed difficult or abstract begin to make sense to a student. This is particularly important in finance and statistics, where students sometimes enter the classroom already believing that the material will be too mathematical or difficult for them. My goal has been to change that perception by creating a classroom in which challenging material feels approachable, relevant, and worth understanding. My teaching philosophy has developed around three principles: making complex ideas intuitive, learning through application, and creating an environment in which students feel comfortable asking questions and making mistakes.

My classes have typically followed a progression from intuition to application. Before introducing an equation or formal model, I establish why we need it and what question it allows us to answer. I then introduce the underlying concept and technical method, connect it to a financial or business decision, work through examples with students, and give them opportunities to practice. In Finance Theory, I emphasize building intuition about valuation and risk before introducing formal models. In Business Statistics, I want students to see statistical methods not simply as mathematical procedures, but as tools for using data to answer business questions. Board exercises, practice problems, and short quizzes allow students to apply what they have learned while allowing me to assess their understanding in real time. I frequently pause, ask questions, and check for hesitation before moving forward because I do not want students to leave a concept behind simply because they were uncomfortable saying that they did not understand it.

Since 2023, I have taught Finance Theory and Business Statistics at the Telfer School of Management, with classes ranging from approximately 30 to 118 students. Across these offerings, my average student evaluation ratings of three important questions have been 4.29/5.0 in Finance Theory and 4.09/5.0 in Business Statistics. Teaching the same courses repeatedly has been particularly valuable because each offering has allowed me to reflect on what worked, listen to students, and refine the organization, pacing, examples, and practice opportunities in subsequent classes. I view student evaluations not simply as measures of teaching performance, but as an important source of feedback for my development as an instructor.

One lesson I have learned is that students enter quantitative courses with very different levels of preparation and confidence. I therefore try not to assume a common starting point. I break complicated problems into manageable steps, explain the intuition behind each step, and gradually increase the level of difficulty. This has been especially meaningful in Business Statistics, where I have worked with students who initially described themselves as struggling with mathematics. Seeing these students become more willing to attempt problems, ask questions, and explain their reasoning has reinforced my belief that rigor and accessibility do not have to be competing goals. Making a difficult idea understandable does not mean reducing its intellectual content; it means finding a clearer path into that content.

Practice and participation have consequently become central to my teaching. I enjoy solving problems *with* students rather than only demonstrating solutions *to* them. When students work through questions on the board, respond to short quizzes, or discuss why an approach does or does not work, I can observe their reasoning rather than simply their final answers. An incorrect answer can sometimes create the most useful teaching moment because it allows us to identify where the reasoning changed direction. Student feedback has also influenced this aspect of my teaching. Students have consistently valued practice examples and board exercises, while some have suggested additional practice before assessments and more opportunities for collaborative problem-solving. I have used this feedback to think more deliberately about balancing explanation with active practice.

Equally important to me is creating a classroom in which students are not afraid to be wrong. I encourage questions, invite students to interrupt me when something is unclear, and make an effort to learn students' names, even in larger classes. My commitment to student learning also extends beyond scheduled class time through office hours, email communication, conversations before and after class, and additional practice materials on Brightspace. Student feedback has helped me determine whether the learning environment I intend to create is also the one students experience. Three comments capture aspects of my teaching that are particularly important to me:

- *“As someone who struggles in math-heavy courses, I found this one to be quite a breeze thanks to your thorough and meticulous explanations of concepts taught in class.”*
- *“There was no fear of being wrong... everyone felt comfortable participating in the class, which greatly enhanced my learning.”*
- *“She very obviously cares about the success of her students. The class was well structured, which made the progression from simple to more complex topics relatively easy to keep up with.”*

My development as an instructor began before I independently taught these courses. From 2019 to 2024, I served as a teaching assistant in Finance Theory, Business Statistics, Options and Futures, Financial Management, Strategic Management, Alternative Investments and Risk Management, and Health Economics. Working across these courses exposed me to different instructors, student populations, and levels of quantitative material. These experiences taught me that effective teaching cannot rely on a single method and provided an important foundation for developing my own teaching identity.

My teaching has also been shaped by my research. Research has trained me to move continually between theory, empirical evidence, and economic interpretation, and I bring the same progression into the classroom. Whether students are learning valuation in Finance Theory or statistical analysis in Business Statistics, I want them to understand not only how a model works, but also what its results mean. Whenever possible, I use current events, real companies, financial data, and examples from research to demonstrate that the concepts students encounter in class are tools for understanding real financial and business decisions.

I view teaching as an evolving practice rather than a finished skill. With every course I have taught, I have become more attentive to how students respond to different explanations, where they tend to struggle, and how course structure can encourage participation and deeper learning. Going forward, I plan to expand my use of real financial and corporate datasets, structured group problem-solving, and applied cases, while continuing to develop assessments that reward interpretation and reasoning rather than memorization.

Ultimately, I want students to leave my classroom with more than knowledge of finance or statistics. I want them to have greater confidence in their ability to approach an unfamiliar problem, break it into manageable pieces, use evidence to analyze it, and explain what their answer means. Some of the most meaningful feedback I have received has come from students who entered a course expecting the material to be intimidating and left believing that they could understand it. For me, that transformation- from uncertainty to understanding and from hesitation to confidence- is one of the most rewarding parts of teaching and continues to shape the teacher I strive to become.